Yet it does suffer from the same inability to define a modern, inclusive view of citizenship. The never-ending conflict continues to undermine the fragile coexistence with Israel's own Arab minority, even as the latter has become more focused on securing its own rights than liberating the Palestinians across the Green Line. In a state conceived as a home for all Jews, racial and religious divisions have created a strikingly unequal society; the same goes for its supposedly unified capital in Jerusalem. The Likud has controlled politics for much of the past forty years, yet it continues to act like a beleaguered opposition party, lashing out at generals, journalists, artists, activists—the increasingly powerless voices of Israel's real opposition.

Presiding over all of this for nearly a decade is Netanyahu, with his American upbringing and mellifluous Philadelphia accent. In many ways, he has been the perfect prime minister for this inflection point in Israel's history. If he were to leave office tomorrow, it is hard to imagine the headline on his political obituary. Begin signed a lasting peace treaty with Egypt; Rabin did the same with Jordan. Barak ended the decades-long occupation of southern Lebanon. Sharon withdrew from Gaza. Peres oversaw vital economic reforms. Even Ehud Olmert, sitting in his prison cell, can argue that he pursued a serious peace process with both Syria and the Palestinians.

Netanyahu has simply survived. His views on the peace process are flexible, depending on what language he's speaking and whether or not an election is on the calendar. In his third government, he agreed to a plan to draft ultra-Orthodox men into the army; in his fourth, he postponed it. He announced the mixed-gender prayer space at the Western Wall to great fanfare, but never opened it. He spent years describing Iran as the greatest threat to world peace, until he lost the battle to block the nuclear deal, when he promptly stopped talking about it. His promise to lower prices and housing costs has gone unfulfilled. Even his wars have been indecisive. "1973 was the last time when both sides said, okay, let's make a deal," said Oded Eran, a longtime Israeli diplomat. "All of the wars since ended with a UN resolution, which was only partially effective, or the arrangement of 2012. What does it mean that we end it unilaterally? It means that Israel continues to live under the current circumstances. It's not clear what is actually ending."